

CUSTOMER SERVICE STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE (SOP)

How to Handle Customer General Inquiry SOP

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INTRODUCTION

Describe the purpose of your customer service department - who your customers are and what their needs are.

The primary purpose of the Customer Service Department is to perform all support functions in a repeatable and reliable way, transitioning from haphazard methods to a standardized "One Best Way" for every interaction. By codifying these procedures, we ensure consistency across all service channels and provide the stable baseline necessary for continuous improvement. This SOP is designed to optimize three critical areas of performance: efficiency by streamlining workflows and reducing waste; quality by delivering accurate results that meet customer requirements every time; and safety by minimizing financial and reputational risks to the organization and its clients.

Our customers primarily consist of [External Clients/Policyholders] who rely on our expertise for [Account Management/Technical Support/Conflict Resolution]. Their needs center on receiving swift and accurate resolutions through interactions that are simple, clear, and personal. We recognize that customers do not view interactions as single touchpoints but as end-to-end journeys; therefore, our mission is to make these journeys effortless and empathetic, providing peace of mind and strengthening the emotional connection between the customer and the company.

By following this standardized procedure, staff members contribute to an ownership culture where excellence is not an accident but a predictable and repeatable result.

CUSTOMER SERVICE WORKFLOW

Describe the step-by-step process of handling a customer inquiry from initial contact to resolution. Include how inquiries are logged, acknowledged, routed to the appropriate agent or department, resolved, and closed.

To transition from haphazard individual responses to an organizational "**One Best Way**," our workflow is designed to resolve customer inquiries in a **repeatable and reliable way**. This process ensures we are "**valuing the customer's time**" by focusing on "first-time right" execution and minimizing unnecessary hand-offs.

The following steps outline the end-to-end journey for every customer inquiry:

Step 1: Initial Contact and Identification

- **Receive Inquiry:** Inquiries arrive through various **Contact Channels** (Phone, Email, Live Chat, etc.).
- **Verify Identity:** Use a simplified protocol to verify the customer's identity (e.g., full name and last four digits of account number) to keep the journey **effortless**.

Step 2: Inquiry Logging and Acknowledgment

- **Create Record:** Immediately open a case in the CRM system to make the interaction "visible" and eliminate reliance on memory or unorganized notes.
- **Send Acknowledgment:** Provide the customer with a unique **Case Number** and an automated written acknowledgment via their preferred channel, specifying the expected resolution timeframe.

Step 3: Triage and Prioritization

- **Categorize:** Assign the inquiry to a standardized category (e.g., Billing, Technical Support, General Info) to facilitate accurate routing.
- **Prioritize:** Use the **Priority Matrix** to assign a severity level (Critical, High, Medium, or Normal) based on the impact on the customer.

Step 4: Routing and Ownership

- **Assign Agent:** Route the inquiry to the appropriate **Generalist** or **Specialist** based on the required skill set identified in the **Skills Matrix**.

- **Establish Ownership:** The assigned agent takes full ownership of the solution from start to finish to reduce the number of internal hand-offs that can frustrate customers.

Step 5: Resolution and Value-Add

- **Execute Procedure:** Follow the specific "One Best Way Guide" (SOP) for the identified category.
- **Provide Product-Based Solutions:** Instead of just answering the immediate question, seek to provide broader solutions that add value to the customer's journey and educate them on how the company can meet their needs.
- **Verify Accuracy:** Apply **Poka-Yoke (Mistake-Proofing)** checks before finalizing to ensure the resolution is correct the first time.

Step 6: Validation and Closure

- **Confirm Satisfaction:** Validate with the customer that their issue is fully resolved before marking the case as **Closed** in the system.
- **Issue Feedback Survey:** Trigger an automated survey to gather customer feedback, which serves as an early warning system for potential process gaps.

Step 7: Exception Handling and Continuous Improvement

- **Record Exceptions:** If an inquiry cannot be resolved by the frontline agent, record it on a **tracking sheet**.
- **Huddle Review:** Bring unresolved issues or recurring "sand" (small, persistent problems) to the **Morning Huddle** for root-cause problem solving.
- **Standard Work Update:** If the team discovers a better way to handle a specific inquiry, the Advisory Team will update the SOP to reflect the new organizational standard.

PRIORITY MATRIX

Customize this priority matrix to define your organization's prioritization and escalation procedure. This helps determine how to categorize and respond to customer issues.

Critical	Urgent customer issues that severely impact the customer relationship or business operations (e.g., major service failure, repeated unresolved complaint, safety concern). Must be addressed immediately and escalated to a manager.
High	Significant customer issue affecting multiple customers or causing strong dissatisfaction (e.g., billing error, incorrect shipment, service disruption). It should be resolved within the same business day.
Medium	Routine customer inquiries or complaints that impact service but do not stop business operations (e.g., general product issue, delayed response). Resolution expected within 2–3 business days.
Normal	General information requests or minor issues (e.g., FAQ-type questions, small adjustments). Handled in the normal course of operations.

ESCALATION

Describe your formula for escalating customer issues For example, define when an agent should involve a supervisor, and identify escalation contacts and procedures.

1. Criteria for Escalation (The "When")

An agent must involve a supervisor or specialist if any of the following triggers occur:

- **Severity Level:** Any issue categorized as **"Critical"** in the Priority Matrix (e.g., major service failure or safety concern) must be escalated immediately.
- **Time-Based Limits:** If an inquiry remains unresolved after **two hours** of active handling by a Level 1 agent, it must be escalated to Level 2 support.
- **Policy Exceptions:** Any situation where a frontline agent must say **"no"** to a customer or where an inquiry falls outside documented policy guidelines.
- **Risk Identifiers:** If at any time an agent suspects **fraud** or encounters high financial, reputational, or legal risks.

2. Tiered Escalation Workflow

Our process follows a **Tiered Accountability** structure to ensure problems flow to the people best able to solve them:

- **Tier 1 (Frontline to Team Leader):** For immediate roadblocks or policy clarifications. Team Leaders triage these during **Daily Huddles**.
- **Tier 2 (Team Leader to Group Leader):** If an issue requires cross-functional coordination or involves team-level capacity constraints, it is moved to the **Group-Leader huddle board**.
- **Tier 3 (Group Leader to Senior Leadership):** The most complex or high-stakes problems (e.g., budgetary issues or strategic alignment) are escalated to the **Head of Operations** or **Senior Management**.
- **Technical Path:** Technical system failures follow a specific path from **Level 1 Support** to **Level 2 Specialists** with a final review by the IT Manager for tickets open longer than 48 hours.

3. Documentation Requirements

To prevent the customer from needing to repeat their issue—**"valuing the customer's time"**—all escalations must include:

- **Full Log Notes:** A factual, description of all actions taken attached to the CRM record.
- **Escalation Log Entry:** Details must be recorded in the departmental **Escalation Log** for performance tracking and root-cause analysis.
- **Customer Notification:** The agent must inform the customer that their ticket has been escalated and provide an updated **estimated resolution time**.

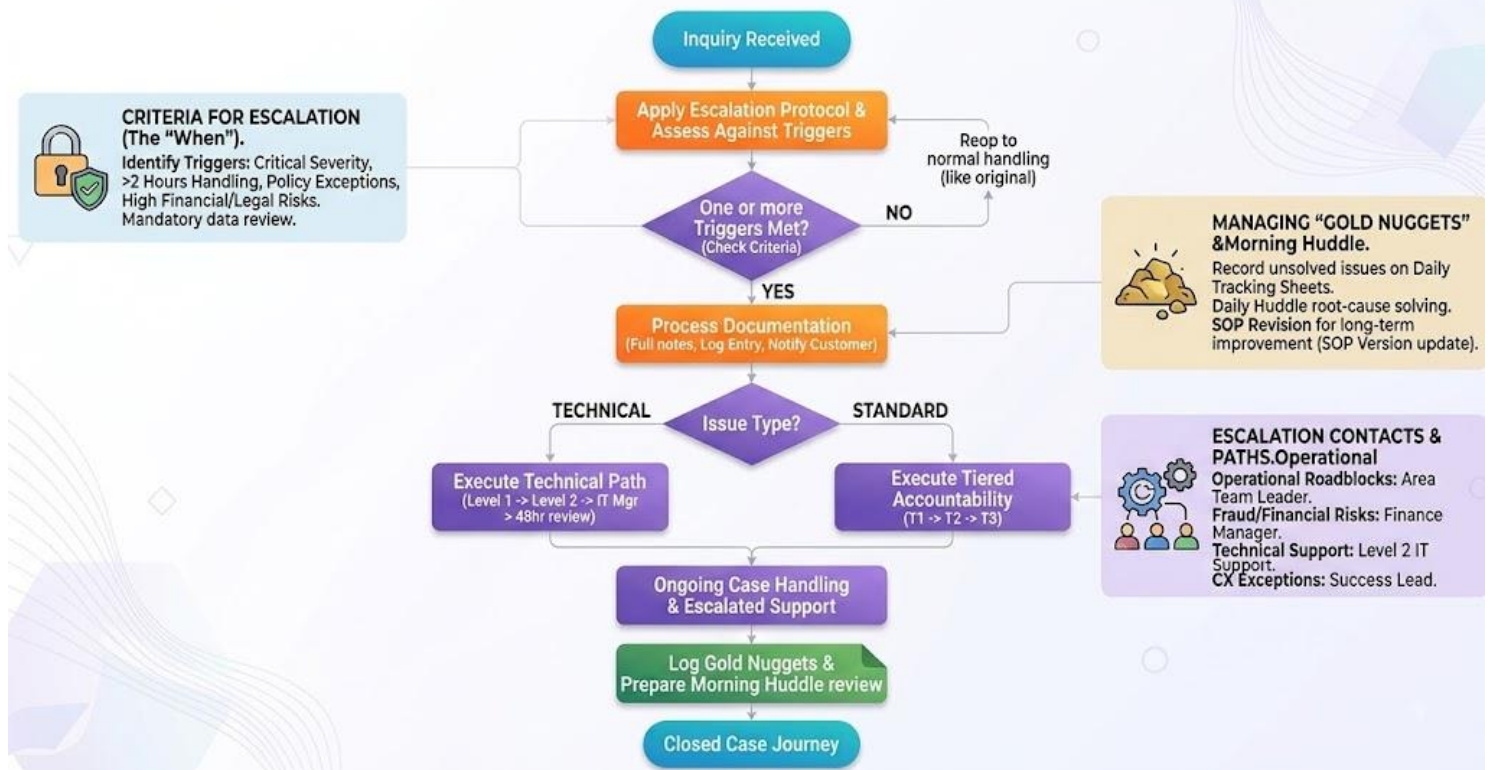
4. Problem Solving and "Gold Nuggets"

Escalated issues that cannot be solved immediately are treated as **"gold nuggets"** for improvement. They are recorded on **daily tracking sheets** and brought to the next **Morning Huddle** to identify if the SOP itself needs a revision or a new "One Best Way". If the resolution requires long-term effort, it is added to a **Tactical Implementation Plan**.

Escalation Contacts

- **Operational Roadblocks:** Area Team Leader
- **Fraud/Financial Risks:** Finance Manager
- **Technical/IT Support:** Level 2 IT Support Desk
- **Customer Experience Exceptions:** Customer Success Lead

A Standardized Escalation Workflow: Criteria & Tiered Accountability



Examples

Provide sample case scenarios to illustrate how the SOP works.

The following sample case scenarios illustrate how the **"One Best Way"** is applied to different customer interactions. These examples demonstrate the transition from haphazard responses to a standardized, reliable workflow that values the customer's time.

Scenario A: Routine Status Inquiry (Normal Priority)

- **Situation:** A customer calls to ask for the expected disbursement date of their processed claim.
- **Channel:** Phone.
- **Action Taken:**

1. **Verification:** The agent uses the **simplified verification protocol** (Full name and last 4 digits of ID) to keep the journey effortless.
 2. **Logging:** The agent opens a CRM record immediately to make the inquiry "visible".
 3. **Triage:** Categorized as "**General Information**" and assigned "**Normal**" priority.
 4. **Resolution:** The agent consults the digital "One Best Way Guide" for status checks and provides the customer with a **specific date** for when the funds will be released.
- **Outcome:** The inquiry is resolved "first-time right" at the point of contact, preventing a follow-up call.

Scenario B: Billing Error (High Priority)

- **Situation:** A customer sends an email stating they were charged twice for their monthly premium.
- **Channel:** Email.
- **Action Taken:**
 1. **Logging & Acknowledgment:** The automated system generates a **Case Number** and sends an acknowledgment within 1 hour.
 2. **Triage:** The agent categorizes this as "**Billing Error**" and assigns "**High**" priority.
 3. **Resolution:** The agent follows the billing reconciliation SOP, identifies the duplicate transaction, and initiates a refund.
 4. **Validation:** The agent sends a personal email confirmation to the customer with the refund transaction number.
- **Outcome:** The issue is resolved within the **same business day**, meeting the High priority SLA.

Scenario C: Unauthorized Account Access (Critical Priority & Escalation)

- **Situation:** A customer reports through Live Chat that they cannot log in and suspect their account has been compromised.
- **Channel:** Live Chat.
- **Action Taken:**
 1. **Identification:** The agent recognizes this as a high-risk security/fraud concern.
 2. **Triage:** Assigned "**Critical**" priority.
 3. **Immediate Escalation:** Following the **Escalation Procedure**, the agent immediately alerts the **Area Team Leader** and the **Fraud Specialist**.
 4. **Ownership:** The Fraud Specialist assumes ownership of the journey, secures the account, and acknowledges the issue with the customer **within 30 minutes**.
 5. **Root-Cause Review:** The incident is recorded as a "**gold nugget**" to be discussed at the next **Morning Huddle** to determine if a Poka-Yoke (mistake-proofing) control is needed in the login process.
- **Outcome:** The risk is mitigated rapidly through tiered accountability, providing the customer with peace of mind.

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